Thapar’s decisive and bold approach immediately after the Nam Ka Chu debacle was heartening. He made most of the decisions while he was in Tezpur on 23 October. Officers observing the chief were pleasantly surprised to see him act this decisively, for in Delhi he seemed to be perpetually incapable of taking any firm decision. He also decided to immediately move 20 Division, situated in the Ranchi-Ramgarh area, into Sikkim with its existing two brigades, which was to be further augmented with 202 Brigade from Calcutta. Both 17 and 20 Divisions were to operate directly under Eastern Command as a stopgap measure. XXXIII Corps was to shift its location immediately from Shillong to Siliguri. And in the west, 3 Division was to be raised with 114 Brigade (with four battalions) to be located at Chushul and 70 Brigade (with 2 battalions plus a troop of armoured cars) to be located at Chumathang to look after the Dumti-Demchok area. 163 Brigade was ordered to move up from the Kashmir Valley to Leh for its close defence.

At Se-la, apart from 62 and 4 Artillery Brigade, two more brigades would be placed under Anant Pathania’s command. 65 Brigade would also get a new commander in Brigadier A. S. Cheema. This formation consisting of 4 Rajput and 19 Maratha Light Infantry (MLI), was given the task of defending Senge Dzong. Finally, 48 Brigade under Brigadier Gurbaksh Singh, consisting of 1 Madras, 5 Guards and 1 Sikh LI, would be given the responsibility of defending Bomdila in the rear.

Unfortunately, Thapar’s forceful behaviour didn’t continue into the third day. On 28 October, the Intelligence Bureau chief had let it be known to select officers in the corridors of power that Lieutenant General Kaul was to take back command of IV Corps and Harbaksh Singh would be moved laterally to take over XXXIII Corps from Lieutenant General Umrao Singh. According to the IB chief, Nehru had told Thapar to implement the order as Kaul was to be pronounced medically fit by the doctors in the next twenty-four hours. Thapar had, according to Mullik, agreed without any semblance of protest. The fact that the IB had intimated the government that the troops in Eastern Command, from the ranks to JCOs and officers, all considered Kaul something of a joke, especially after his unceremonious flight from Nam Ka Chu, didn’t seem to have changed anyone’s mind.

General Pran Thapar’s failure to stand up to Nehru on what would prove to be yet another disastrous decision may have had something to do with another rumour doing the rounds—the impending decision to sack both